HCP 1100 (cpc_1908-10-30_UK_Clapham_UK_Somerset_): an English love note from May, 1908

Human solver: Tomáš Pavuk

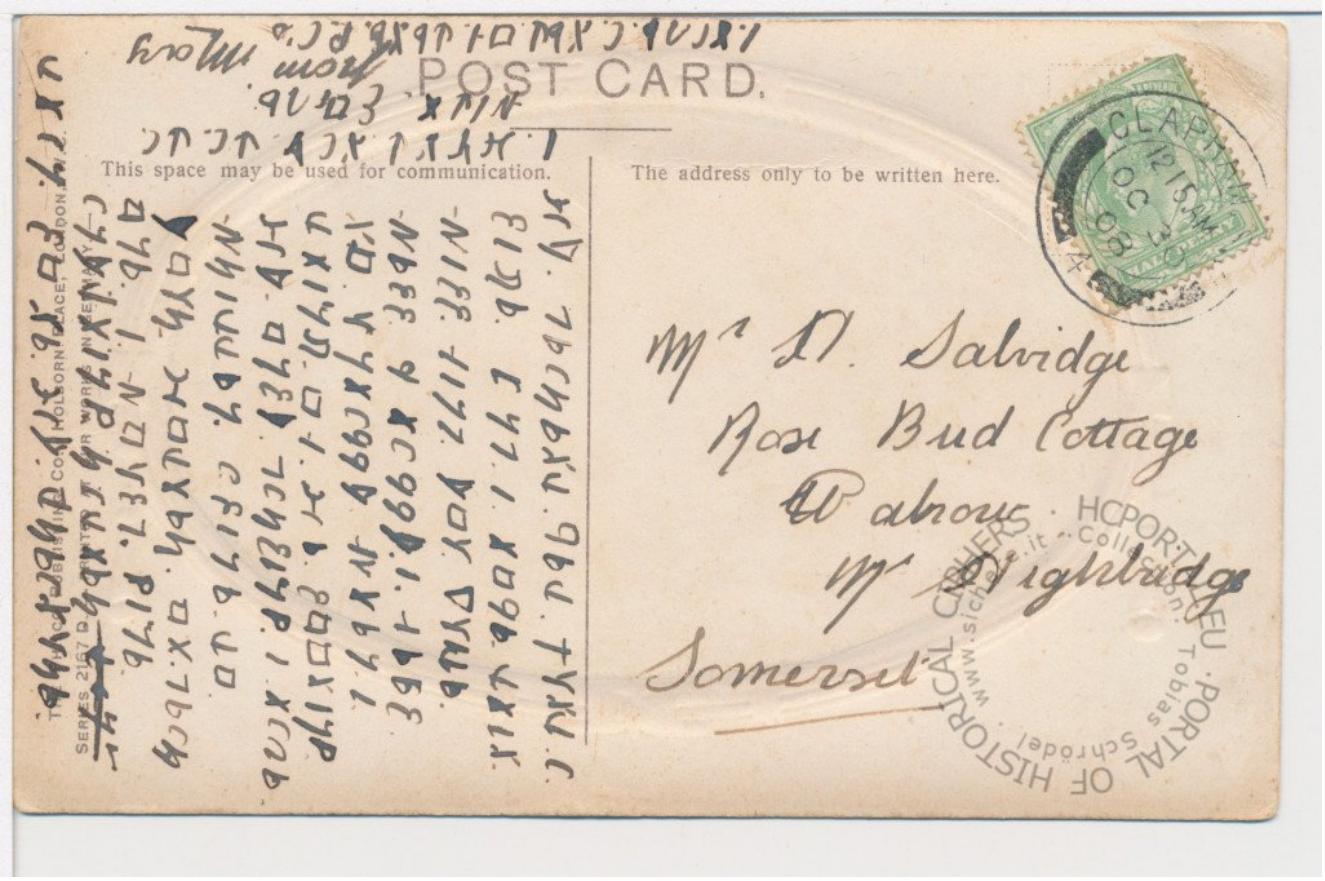
Status: deciphered in full (226 of 226 cipher signs; one struck-out group of about four signs is not decoded); independent review 1 verdict ACCEPT, no change to the decoded letters. Report dated 2026-11-03.

Origin and context

The cryptogram is record 1100 of the HC Portal (https://crypto.hcportal.eu/dashboard/cryptograms/1100), portal name cpc_1908-10-30_UK_Clapham_UK_Somerset_, part of Tobias Schrödel's collection of cryptographic postcards (private collection). When it was captured on 2026-11-03 the portal listed it as **Not solved**, tagged Postcard and T. Schrödel Collection, language Unknown, sender Unknown, recipient Mr. Salvidge, with no transcription or solution attached.

The picture side is a printed embossed card, "Begging a seat", showing two Blenheim spaniels on a cushion beside a vase of wisteria, with the verse "One Blenheim Spaniel / Secures a cushion soft, / Nor makes room for his brother / Though he begs oft." The publisher's imprint on the address side ("The H... Co. Publishing Co., Holborn Place, London W.C., Series 2167 D, printed at our works in Germany") is partly covered by writing.

The address side is in plain writing: **Mr D. Salvidge, Rose Bud Cottage, Walrow, Nr Highbridge, Somerset.** (Walrow is a hamlet by Highbridge in Somerset; the handwriting of the name is not perfectly clear.) The card carries a ½d green Edward VII stamp cancelled **CLAPHAM, 12.15 AM, OC 30 08**, i.e. 30 October 1908.

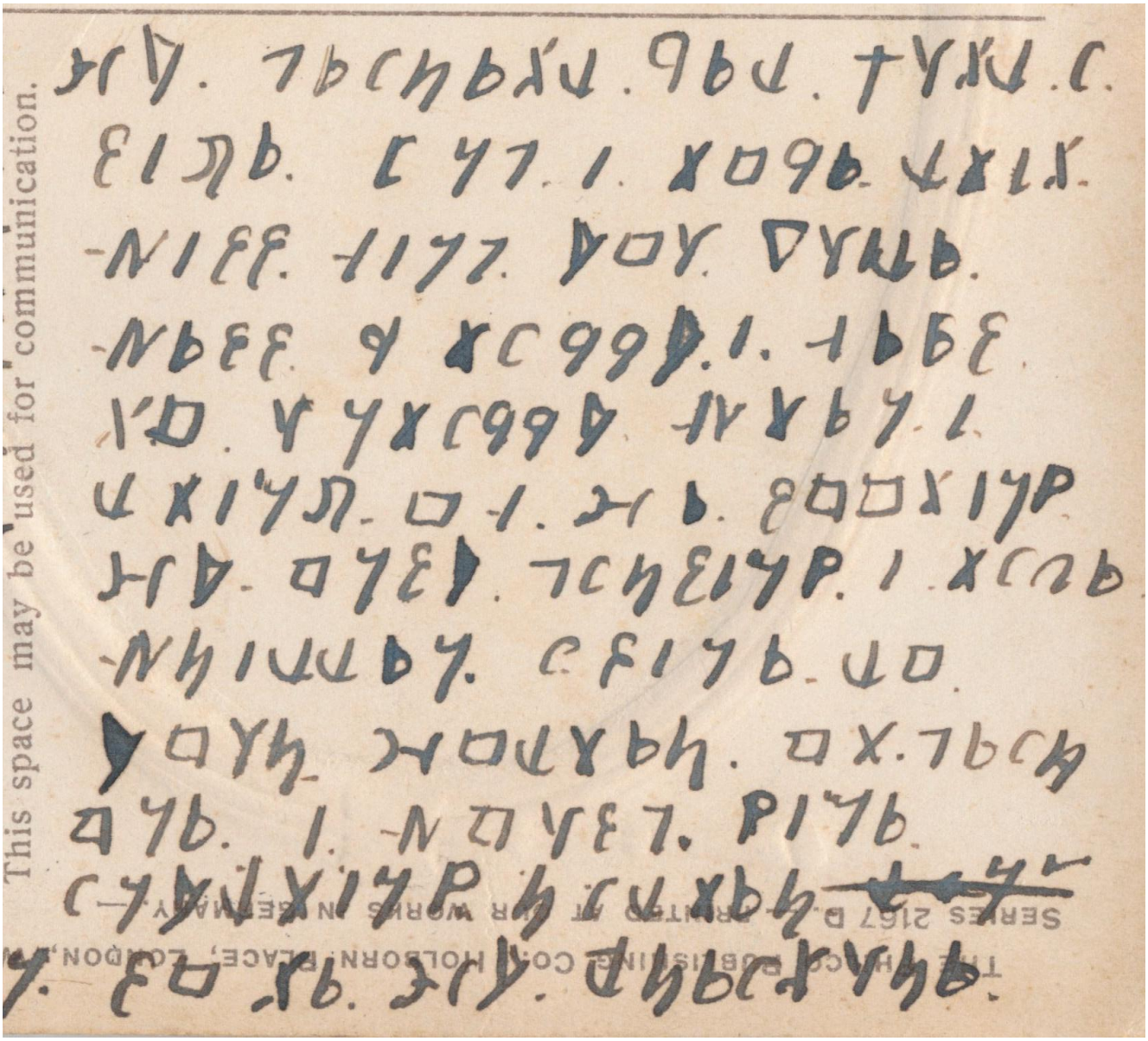


Address side as scanned (source/address-large.jpg)

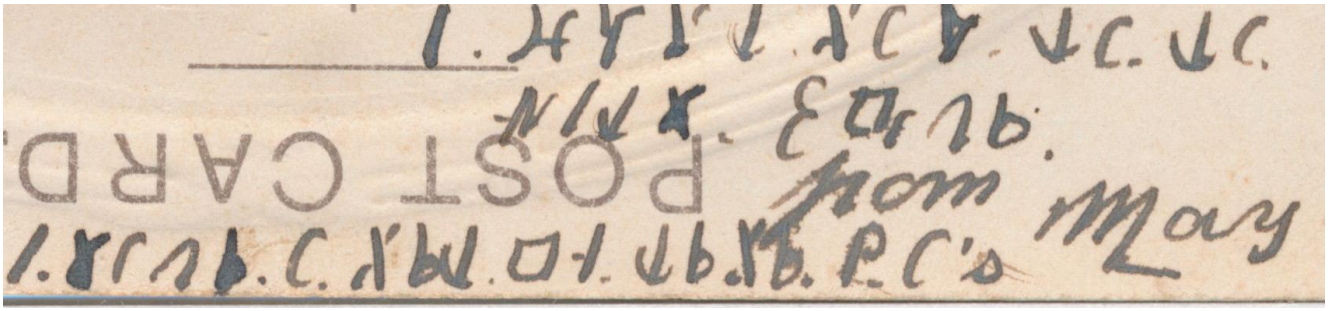


Picture side (source/picture-large.jpg)

The message fills the communication half of the address side. Twelve lines (B01 to B12) are written across it with the card turned 90° clockwise; the last of them runs along the left edge over the printed imprint. Three short lines (T01 to T03) stand at the top, upside down, and the words "P.C's" and "from May" there are in ordinary handwriting.



Body text, card turned 90° clockwise (work/crops/body_rot90.jpg)



Top lines, card turned 180° (work/crops/top180.jpg)

Other marks, none of them cipher: the address, the printed headings and imprint, the stamp and postmark, and the HCPortal watermark on both sides. The picture side carries no handwriting. The stamp is still affixed: nothing is visible at its perforated edges or in the dotted stamp box, but what may lie under it could not be inspected.

Method

There was no earlier solver work on this number. The transcription is **manual**, made by Claude Opus 5.5 from the un-converted high-resolution scan (work/hires/), with enlarged crops of each line (work/crops/). Each sign was given a shape code, and words were separated where the writer put a dot (every enciphered word ends with a dot). The result is work/transcription.txt.

The key was recovered from this card alone; no sister card to Salvidge or from Clapham is known in the repository. The steps were:

- single-sign words: the plain stroke occurs alone repeatedly (I) and the round C occurs alone (A);
- a three-sign ending recurring three times (...I-N-G in LOOSING, DARLING, ANYTHING);
- double letters in WELL, WILL, HAPPY, LOOSING and WRITTEN;
- then confirmation on independent words: DEAREST, DEAR, DARLING (D, R); MOTHER, WITH, RATHER (T, H); HOPE, HAPPY, UNHAPPY (P); LOVE, HAVE, GIVE (V).

The writer forms several letters in two to four slightly different shapes. These were kept as separate shape codes and each was assigned from the word it occurs in; the main shape of every letter is attested several times in independent words.

In review a separate Claude Opus 5.5 agent made its own crops of the scan, compared the transcription line by line, and decoded it with its own independently written key table and script. Its output was identical to the solver's: 226 signs, no unknown code, no unused code, no shape mapped to two letters.

Key

Monoalphabetic substitution with invented signs; the descriptions are for the card turned 90° clockwise.

Letter	Main sign	Variant shapes
A	round C	angular C (AND), thin arc "(" (MAY, THAN), Γ-like hook (RATHER, HAVE)
D	7	
E	b	b with top bar (FEEL), solid triangular b (WELL, HAVE), loop-and-stem (RATHER, TREASURE)
F	stroke with a hyphen at the left	
G	P	
H	Y shape with a heavy ink foot	
I	plain stroke	
J	dagger cross	
K	Cyrillic Л shape	
L	epsilon Ɛ	reversed 3 (WELL, FEEL, ONLY), z-hook (LOSE)
M	hook with a horizontal bar	
N	ч / y shape with a left arm	ɳ shape (LINE in B02)
O	square	open 4-like box with stem (ONE)
P	9	
Q	closed downward triangle ∇	
R	hooked h	

Letter	Main sign	Variant shapes
S	stroke with a foot at lower left and a tick at upper right	
T	u with a tall right stem	tall plain stroke (ANYTHING), d-loop with crossbar (TREASURE)
U	V with stem	V with tick (UNHAPPY)
V	stroke with a curl at the top	
W	hyphen + N	
Y	V/Y with a pennant or triangle, open or filled	
&	ə-like sign standing alone, without a word dot (B04)	

B, C, X and Z do not occur.

Plaintext

Literal English as decoded, line by line (word dots dropped; "P.C's" and "from May" are plain writing on the card):

```
B01 MAY DEAREST PET JUST A
B02 LINE AND I HOPE THIS
B03 WILL FIND YOU QUITE
B04 WELL & HAPPY I FEEL
B05 SO UNHAPPY WHEN I
B06 THINK OF MAY LOOSING
B07 MAY ONLY DARLING I HAVE
B08 WRITTEN A LINE TO
B09 YOUR MOTHER OH DEAR
B10 ONE I WOULD GIVE
B11 ANYTHING RATHER [about four signs struck out]
B12 THAN LOSE MAY TREASURE
T01 I MUST SAY TA TA
T02 WITH LOVE
T03 I HAVE A SET OF TESE P.C's
T04 from May
```

The possessive is spelled M-A-Y all four times (B01, B06, B07, B12). It reads naturally as "my"; the writer, who signs "May", is probably playing on her name. The literal text keeps MAY; the translations give "my".

English (normalised): **My dearest pet, just a line, and I hope this will find you quite well and happy. I feel so unhappy when I think of my losing my only darling. I have written a line to your mother. Oh, dear one, I would give anything rather than lose my treasure. I must say ta-ta. With love, from May. I have a set of these postcards.**

Slovak translation: **Môj najdrahší miláčik, len pár riadkov a dúfam, že ťa zastihnú celkom zdravého a šťastného. Cítim sa taká nešťastná, keď pomyslím na to, že strácam svojho jediného miláčika. Napísala som pár riadkov tvojej mame. Ach, drahý, dala by som čokoľvek, len aby som nestratila svoj poklad. Musím sa rozlúčiť, pá-pá. S láskou, May. Mám sadu týchto pohľadníc.**

Notes on the reading:

- **LOOSING** (for losing) and **TESE** (for these, with no H sign on the card) are the writer's spellings and are kept in the literal text.
- **TA TA** is the period colloquial "goodbye"; "just a line ... I hope this will find you quite well" is a standard opening of Edwardian postcards.
- **"I have a set of these P.C's"** refers to the picture postcards themselves; the plain "P.C's" follows the enciphered words directly.

Reproduction

From the repository root:

```
python3 -I ciphers/hcp-1100/work/decode.py
```

The script uses only the Python standard library. It checks the SHA-256 hashes of the two source images and the two high-resolution originals ("source hashes OK"), applies the key to the manual transcription work/transcription.txt and prints lines B01 to B12 and T01 to T04 exactly as above. It does not read the image; the transcription step is manual and was checked independently in review.

Uncertainties

- **Variant shapes resting on word sense.** Eight variant shapes occur only once: angular C as A (AND), b with top bar as E (FEEL), ɳ as N (LINE), 4-like box as O (ONE), tall stroke and d-loop as T (ANYTHING, TREASURE), V with tick as U (UNHAPPY), z-hook as L (LOSE). The solid triangular b (E) occurs twice, in WELL and HAVE. Each fits its word and none affects the reading as a whole. The ɳ of LINE resembles the Л sign for K in THINK; it is read N because "just a LIKE" makes no sense and LINE recurs in B08 with the ordinary N. The thin-arc A and the Γ-hook A may be one shape drawn with more or less hook.
- **The "&" sign** (B04) is a single ə-like sign between WELL and HAPPY; its value comes from word sense. It is the only enciphered word without a following dot, which fits a logogram rather than a letter.
- **MAY = "my"** is an interpretation of four literal M-A-Y groups.
- **The struck-out group** at the end of B11 (about four signs under one heavy stroke) is not decoded; its shapes suggest a false start of THAN, which then opens B12.
- **Order of the top lines.** "from May" stands to the right between T02 and T03; it may close "With love" or belong to the P.C's line. The reading does not change.
- **Under the stamp.** The stamp has not been lifted, so the area under it could not be inspected. Nothing is visible at its edges, in the stamp box or on the picture side, so the card is classed as plain MASC, not MASC with steganography.
- The place name Walrow and the publisher's name are plain handwriting or print, partly obscured, and outside the cipher.
- A short web search for a published solution of this card ("Salvidge", "Rose Bud Cottage", Clapham 1908 cipher postcard) found none on 2026-11-03.

Review summary

Reviewer: Claude Opus 5.5 (Anthropic), round 1, verdict **ACCEPT**. The reviewer ran the reproduction command (output as claimed), wrote its own key table and decoder (identical output, 226 signs, no unknown or unused code), compared the transcription with its own crops of the scan line by line, and confirmed in particular the literal M-A-Y groups, TESE, RATHER, TREASURE, the S sign in LOOSING and the plain-letter top lines. It found no hidden writing at the stamp or on the picture side. Its four findings were minor and are reflected here:

- **"Under the stamp" wording.** The claim was too strong; it now says the area under the affixed stamp could not be inspected.
- **Single-occurrence variants.** The E with a top bar (FEEL) was added to the list.
- **"&" without a word dot.** Now noted as support for the logogram reading.
- **Two A shapes.** The thin arc and the Γ-hook A may be one shape; noted.

No decoded letter changed as a result of the review. The transcription, key reconstruction and decipherment were made by Claude Opus 5.5; there was no earlier work by another model on this card.

Sources

- HC Portal record 1100, General, Description and Attachments tabs, captured 2026-11-03: https://crypto.hcportal.eu/dashboard/cryptograms/1100 (source/metadata.md).
- Picture side: https://api.hcportal.eu/media/3360/conversions/cpc_1908-10-30_UK_Clapham_UK_Somerset__pic-large.jpg (source/picture-large.jpg) and its original (work/hires/).
- Address side: https://api.hcportal.eu/media/3361/conversions/cpc_1908-10-30_UK_Clapham_UK_Somerset__adr-large.jpg (source/address-large.jpg) and its original (work/hires/).
- Portal reference: https://ecp.ep.liu.se/index.php/histocrypt/article/view/166 (paper on the postcard collection, as linked by the portal).
- AI Decipherment Register (https://ai.hcportal.eu/register/), checked 2026-11-03 by the orchestrator: no entry for this card.